

How to read a NOPSEMA record without overreading it

Public regulatory records are valuable when their status, scope and date travel with every conclusion drawn from them.

1. Identify the record before summarising it

Start by recording the titleholder, named activity, document type, submission or issue date, revision and displayed status. Save the date on which the public record was checked. Those details form the boundary of the claim: a decision relating to one activity or revision should not silently become a statement about an entire field.

NOPSEMA's environment-plan portal distinguishes proposals open for comment, submissions under assessment and approved projects and activities. It explicitly states that plans on the open-for-comment page have not undergone NOPSEMA assessment. Public availability therefore does not itself establish regulatory acceptance. [Environment-plan portal](#).

2. Read status together with scope

An accepted plan should be read for the activity it covers, including its boundaries, commitments and exclusions. A decommissioning program can involve different work at different times. Cleaning, well abandonment, topsides removal and a final end state should not be assumed to sit inside the same accepted scope simply because they concern the same asset.

Use a simple record map. Put the question in one column, the relevant public record beside it and the conclusion that the record supports in a third. Add a fourth column for what remains unestablished. This makes the analysis useful for a board or project team without suggesting that a public portal contains every document the regulator has considered.

01	02	03	04
Submission	Assessment outcome	Notified start	Completion evidence

Fig. 04.1 / Illustrative decision sequence. Project-specific evidence and assessment remain necessary.

3. Preserve the meaning of enforcement terminology

NOPSEMA publishes directions, improvement notices and prohibition notices, but explains that the publication provisions do not cover every type of letter or enforcement action. Its register also explains that a notice marked closed means the duty holder has notified NOPSEMA of compliance. A revoked direction is cancelled from the specified date. These terms should be reproduced with that meaning rather than expanded into a broader assurance statement. [Published directions and notices](#).

Read the underlying notice and related documents when they are available. Record exactly who must do what, by when and in relation to which facility or activity. Do not infer the current condition of an asset from the title of a historic notice alone. Equally, an absence of a result in a keyword search is not evidence that no relevant regulatory action exists.

4. Separate activity permission from title surrender

NOPSEMA's March 2026 Section 270 policy describes its advice to the Joint Authority on title surrender. The Joint Authority makes the surrender decision. That is a different decision from acceptance of an activity's environment plan. [Section 270 policy](#).

For a practical review, distinguish three statements: what the titleholder proposed; what the regulator's published record says; and what engineering inference is being made. Place a source and checked date beside the first two. Mark the third as interpretation and state what evidence could change it.

The resulting reading note should allow someone else to reproduce the search and challenge the conclusion. It should not rank an operator's compliance, assert completion of unobserved work or claim that a particular liability has disappeared unless the relevant evidence directly supports that conclusion.

Source notes

1. [Environment-plan portal](#)
2. [Published directions and notices](#)
3. [Section 270 policy](#)
4. [NOPSEMA decommissioning overview](#)

Source baseline: 10 September 2026. Updated 14 September 2026. Jurisdiction and reporting-period applicability must be considered for the actual scope.